

The wariness about taking ideological support all the way to actual representation becomes clearer if you examine the other parties that tout pro-Muslim politics. The TMC has fielded only six Muslim candidates in its list of 42, the SP has only four among its 57, and the RJD boasts only two among its 24 candidates. Of the other top three parties of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA)—the DMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam), NCP (Nationalist Congress Party-Sharadchandra Pawar) and Sena (UBT)—only the NCP (SP) has fielded one.

Political leaders, too, in private concede that fielding Muslim candidates is electorally counter-productive. While the Hindus are unlikely to vote for a Muslim candidate in a Hindu-majority area, such an experiment often causes fragmentation of votes in Muslim-majority seats. Feyaad Allie, a post-doctoral fellow at Harvard University, points out that the existence of a Muslim representative can activate internal divisions among Muslims and shape their subsequent voting behaviour. Consequently, they end up voting in favour of their sub-identities and not for a larger collective goal.

The BJP's Dual Game

While they may not be the party of choice for most Muslims, the BJP still cornered 7 per cent of the overall Muslim vote in 2019, down from 9 per cent in 2014 but still higher than the 4 per cent in 2009. As Hilal Ahmed points out, the party has now adopted a dual strategy—demonising Muslims for its core vote base while wooing certain sections of the Muslim population with social welfare schemes and development. "There is a significant outreach to Muslims through three schemes—the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana and the PM Awas Yojana, particularly in the northern states," says Ahmed. "This is part of the process of neutralising anti-BJP voting among Muslim voters." With this strategy, BJP leaders expect to take their vote share among Muslims to over 15 per cent, though most experts deem it a highly implausible target.

The saffron party also wants to capitalise on the sectarian divisions within the community—Shia, Sunni, Sufi, Deobandi et al. The biggest outreach, though, is towards the socially backward Muslims, collectively known as the Pasmanda (Persian for "those left behind"), who comprise around 57 per cent of the overall Muslim population. The prime minister had, in fact, urged the BJP workers to reach out to the Pasmanda Muslims during the BJP's national executive meeting in Hyderabad in 2022.

The party has since then made several moves to engage with Pasmanda individuals. It has, for instance, fielded M. Abdul Salam—the party's sole Muslim candidate in 2024—from the Malappuram Lok Sabha constituency in Kerala, nominated former Aligarh Muslim University vice-chancellor Tariq Mansoor to the election manifesto committee and fielded several Pasmanda Muslim candidates in the municipal elections in Delhi and UP. In addition, the party has launched several outreach programmes, such as 'Samvad', 'Sneh Yatra', 'Qaumi Chaupal', 'Shukriya Modi Bhaijaan', to connect with the Muslims and allay their fears around contentious issues such as the NRC and CAA. More than 25,000 Muslims, including educators, entrepreneurs, clerics and retired government employees, have been enlisted as 'Modi Mitrs (friends)', whose task is to publicise how the BJP government's religion-agnostic socio-economic measures are benefitting the Muslims too.

Experts believe the voting pattern of Pasmanda Muslims in 2024 will determine the future narrative around the so-called Muslim vote bank. "If the BJP is even moderately successful in consummating its outreach to Pasmanda Muslims, researchers may need to retire the idea of a Muslim voting bloc and pursue a comprehensive, nuanced understanding of how and when sub-identities shape Muslim voting behaviour," writes Allie in a research paper published this year.

However, seen against the backdrop of the BJP's vitriolic communal campaign to consolidate Hindu votes—in which Muslims are the villain—the apprehension against the party remains widespread within the community across class and sect. Even the Pasmandas are unlikely to fall for the BJP's carrots, many experts say. "Pasmandas want reservation," says Engineer. "But the prime minister has categorically declined the possibility of including Pasmandas or any Muslim in the reservation pie."

Lack of Muslim Leaders

Indian Muslims have since Independence largely backed secular formations such as the Congress, SP, BSP (Bahujan Samaj Party), TMC and RJD. While these parties have talked about protecting Muslim interests, they have been less forthcoming in giving them proportional representation. Based on their share of population, the ideal number of Muslim MPs in the Lok Sabha should be 76. Muslim representation in Parliament in the Congress-dominated years of 1952-1977 was 2-7 per cent. The